

CIM301 Handbook

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Week 1 - Introduction to Being an Autodidact

Autodidacticism

Autodidacticism refers to the concept of “self-teaching”; that is, identifying some topic or skill that one would like to improve in, and carrying out the process of developing the knowledge or skill by some form of pedagogical process.

This class is entirely built around this concept. You’re asked to identify a skill you would like to improve in, design a project that will allow you to develop this skill, then carry out the project and continually reflect on and adjust the project.

It is a very important skill to have as the industry is constantly shifting with new tools, practices, demands, etc. The industry requires us to identify when some new practice is demanded of us – however big or small – and then to develop this skill on our own.

Autodidacticism is incredibly empowering. It is the meta-skill that allows us to continually improve, grow as professionals and in our respective crafts. It also allows us to begin to hollow out a particular niche, making our own skill sets more original, rare, and unique. This leads to creative work that is innovative and singular.

It applies not only to our professional work, but to any skill – cooking, painting, writing, running, etc.

Autodidacticism teaches us *how to learn anything we want*.

Being a proficient autodidact involves being able to accurately identify current demands for certain skills, realistically evaluate one’s own skill set (our strengths and weaknesses), articulate a goal to develop proficiency in a particular skill, design the correct type of project that will allow us to achieve that goal, and most importantly, engage and persevere with the project.

However, an important thing to point out is that autodidacticism is not simply ‘working on things in isolation’. A major part of skill development is the seeking, receiving and reflection on **valuable feedback**. That is why this unit revolves so heavily around the incorporation of mentors and feedback. In these sessions (which begin halfway through the trimester), you will be regularly showing your work created throughout the week to your mentors and peers, who will provide feedback. This feedback is logged, and (most importantly) you will be reflecting on it to understand how to use it to improve your workflows and techniques. Sure, the majority of the work is carried out individually, but receiving feedback from knowledgeable people is what allows your practices to continuously be developed and strengthened.

Throughout this unit, you will be introduced to the frameworks associated with this process:

1. identify demands for particular skills (**industry skills analysis**)
2. assess their own skill set and identify areas that need improving (**SWOT analysis**)
3. establishing an appropriate goal to develop that skill (**SMARTER goals**)
4. building an effective project plan to achieve that goal (**deliberate practice**)
5. carrying out and persevering with the project (**grit**)

Key Tools

The key tools for carrying out any project are:

1. Calendar
2. Notepad
3. Task List

A calendar is of course essential for planning out when you'll be working, and also *what* you'll be working on.

A notepad is the place for dumping ideas, sketching out plans, logging any feedback, pulling together inspiration and mood boards, reflecting on the project's progress, putting in project timelines, etc. A notepad can be analog or digital. For this class, feel free to use the project documentation templates for this, or use a blank Google Doc. Digital is preferred as, working in the digital media field, we use plenty of links, images, videos, etc. If you prefer to write or sketch things out by hand, feel free to do so and scan into a digital document. Note: 'scanning' a document is not the same as taking a photo of it. Look into apps that scan documents and create .pdf's of them.

A task list is essential for planning out the smaller actions that need to get done over the course of the project. As we'll go through, breaking down a project into its smaller chunks is an essential and valuable skill in project planning. There are a range of different task list formats, but you can go for the typical dot-point style of task list, or something like a Kanban Framework, which has been popularised by the Trello platform.

If you would like a platform that has all of these elements contained within it, my best recommendation is [Notion](#) (it's free).

The important thing about these platforms is that you find the one(s) that works for you, and then you stick with it, working out of it whenever you're working on the project. You'll make it a habit to open the program as you sit down at your desk to do project work.

Week 2 - Industry Skills Analysis & Identifying Personal Skills Gaps

Industry Skills Analysis

As mentioned above, part of being a proficient autodidact is being constantly aware of the demands of the industry one works within, and the constant changes that are occurring to these. Our current time is characterised by drastic changes to our technologies, as many industries are being impacted and reshaped by emerging tech.

To guide the process of identifying industry skills, here are four key questions to ask:

- What are the key skills and competencies currently in demand within your field?
- How is technology changing or expected to change your field in the next five years?
- What emerging trends or innovations in your field are most exciting to you?
- What challenges are companies or professionals in your field currently facing?

To begin to identify how to approach these demands and changes to them, here are four additional questions to ask:

- How can you begin developing these skills currently in demand?
- What opportunities do these current and forecasted technological changes present for new professionals?
- How might you position yourself to take advantage of these opportunities?
- What creative solutions could you offer to address these challenges?

Personal Skills Analysis

To analyse one's own skill set, the SWOT framework can be helpful. The SWOT framework (or, a "SWOT analysis") identifies the strengths and weaknesses of one's own skillset. Carrying out this stage of the analysis requires one to look internally. However, it also requires one to explore the external factors related to the application of a skill set in the industry: opportunities opened up by one's current or desired skill set, and threats or challenges posed to particular workers with these skills.

Strengths (Internal, Positive)

These are the skills, qualities, and experiences you feel confident in. Consider:

- What do you enjoy and feel skilled at?
- What personal qualities help you in your work or creative projects?
- What relevant experience, interests and skills do you have that might be unique to you?
- What feedback have you received about your strengths?

Example: A strong ear for sound design, the ability to write clearly and concisely, being particularly proficient with a piece of software.

Weaknesses (Internal, Areas for Growth)

These are areas where you might want to improve or develop further. Ask yourself:

- What skills would you like to strengthen?
- Are there any habits or patterns that hold you back?
- Are there areas where you feel less confident?
- Do you find certain tasks more challenging than others?

Example: Wanting to improve public speaking, developing better time management, learning a new piece of software to expand your creative practice, developing piano playing skills or knowledge of how synthesis works.

Opportunities (External, Available Applications of the Skills)

These are areas where your skills can be put to use in practical or professional settings. Think about:

- What kinds of jobs, roles, or projects align with your skill set?
- Are there industries, fields or jobs where your abilities would be especially useful?
- Are there gaps in the market where your skills could be valuable?
- Are there trends or changes that create demand for what you do?

Example: A composer skilled in sound design might find opportunities in film, video games, or immersive installations. A strong writer might apply their skills in journalism, content creation, or academic research. A producer with excellent mixing abilities could find work in music, podcasting, broadcasting, or live sound.

Threats (External, Challenges to Applying Your Skills)

These are external factors that might make it more difficult to find or sustain work using your skills. Consider:

- Are there shifts in the industry that reduce demand for your skill set?
- Is there high competition in your field that makes it harder to find work?
- Are there technological advancements that could replace or devalue your skills?
- Are there economic, legal, or cultural changes that might impact opportunities?

Example: A musician working in composing for advertisements might face decreasing demand due to AI-generated music. A freelance writer might struggle if companies cut budgets for written content creation. A live sound engineer might find fewer opportunities if venues increasingly rely on in-house staff instead of hiring freelancers.

Horizons of Focus

David Allen's "Horizons of Focus" is a framework from his Getting Things Done (GTD) methodology that helps individuals organise their tasks and goals across different levels of perspective (Allen, 2015). It consists of six horizons, each representing a progressively broader view of one's life and priorities:

- Ground level: Day-to-day actions—current tasks and to-do lists.
- Horizon 1: Projects—short-term goals that require multiple steps to complete.
- Horizon 2: Areas of responsibility—key roles and ongoing commitments, such as a job, study or family.
- Horizon 3: Goals—short to medium-term objectives (1-2 years).
- Horizon 4: Vision—long-term aspirations (3-5 years).
- Horizon 5: Purpose and values—the fundamental reasons for actions, guiding principles, and life mission.

Each horizon helps clarify actions, align tasks with higher goals, and ensure that daily activities contribute to long-term success.

Week 3 - SMARTER Goals & Deliberate Practice

SMARTER Goals

SMARTER goals are a framework for setting clear and achievable objectives. The acronym stands for:

Specific: The goal is well-defined and focused.

Measurable: Progress and success can be tracked with quantifiable criteria.

Achievable: The goal is realistic and attainable given the available resources.

Relevant: The goal aligns with broader objectives and is meaningful.

Time-bound: There is a clear deadline or timeframe for completion.

Evaluated: Regularly assess progress and performance.

Revised: Adjust the goal as needed based on feedback or changing circumstances.

Using SMARTER goals helps ensure that objectives are clear, realistic, and trackable. The framework should be **used as a checklist** to ensure the goal statement is as clear and achievable as possible.

Deliberate Practice

Deliberate practice is a structured and purposeful approach to improving a skill. It involves focussed, consistent practice with the goal of mastering specific aspects of a task. Key characteristics of an appropriate deliberate practice plan are:

- **Goal-oriented:** Each session targets a specific skill or weakness.
 - a. Break down the project into manageable chunks and milestones.
 - b. Plan exactly what you're going to be working on in each session.
- **Challenging:** Tasks push beyond current abilities to encourage growth.
- **Repetitive:** Skills are refined through repeated, focused effort.
- **Feedback-driven:** Regular feedback is essential to identify mistakes and guide improvement.
- **Reflection:** The project plan is periodically evaluated and adjusted based on reflections on progress.

Unlike regular practice, deliberate practice is highly intentional, aiming for gradual and sustained improvement through focused effort. Deliberate practice is often exhausting as each session aims to *develop* a new skill, rather than only *applying* existing ones.

Week 4 - Gantt Charts & Journaling

Gantt Charts

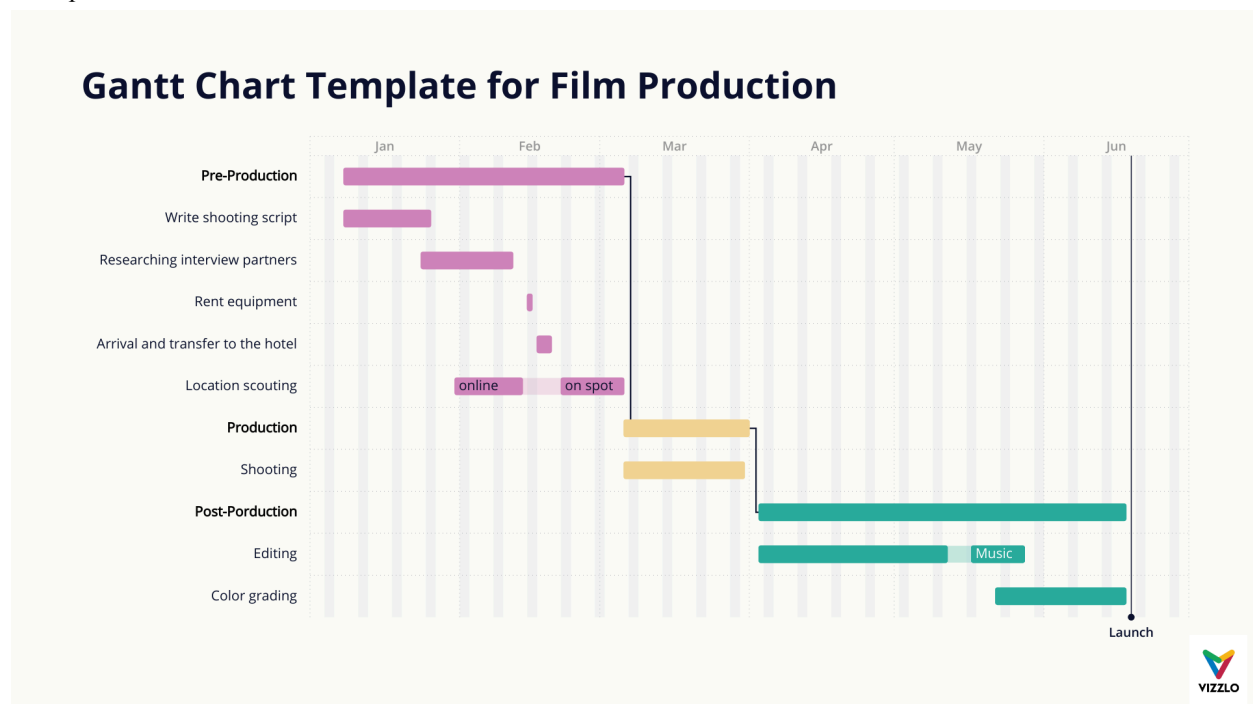
Let's look at how goals, projects and tasks are all interlinked with each other.

To achieve some **goal**, you have to undertake a **project** over a course of time. To make a project achievable, it should be broken down into chunks of some kind. The ability to do this 'chunking' – to break a project down into its smaller components – is a core part of project planning. These chunks will be in different sizes; in bigger projects, they'll first be the different stages of the project (eg, ideation, production, writing, editing, colouring, mastering, marketing, etc.). Then, within these stages, the project is broken down further into smaller chunks. These are the individual **tasks** that need to be completed during the stages of the project. Each day while you're working on the project, you'll be working on specific tasks. Once you complete one task, you move onto the next. Once you complete all tasks in one stage, you move onto the next stage – if this is a project that has stages that are dependent on the completion of previous ones, which is commonly the case. Once all the stages are done, the project is completed. Some projects are smaller and don't really have stages, but all projects must be broken down into smaller tasks in order to be more achievable and manageable.

In this way, you don't just *do the project*, you do one **task** after another until you've completed them all, at which point the **project** will have been completed, and you will have achieved your **goal**.

Gantt charts are a type of visualised timeline used typically in project planning. They use both the X and Y axes, showing time from left to right and each task of the project from top to bottom. The project begins in the top left, and ends in the bottom right.

Example Gantt Chart:



Key components of a GANTT chart:

- **Tasks:** The individual steps or activities needed to complete the project.
- **Timeline:** Dates or time periods for starting and completing tasks.
- **Dependencies:** Relationships between tasks (e.g., Task B can only start after Task A is completed). These are illustrated using a line linking separate tasks.
- **Milestones:** Significant stages, points or achievements within the project.

There are plenty of services which allow you to create Gantt charts. If you're looking for a simple option, use [this website](#).

Journaling

Journaling can be an incredibly useful tool for creative and productive people. It is a very useful tool for ensuring emotional awareness & clarity, professional and personal growth, and logging information. There is great value in externalising our ideas about things going on in our lives. Journaling can help identify personal challenges, achievements, and areas for improvement, which is essential for ongoing development.

Everyone approaches journaling in different ways. Some people enjoy simply dot-pointing and short sentences about what they're up to, how they're going, how they're feeling. Others use it to track things going on in their lives such as moods, habits, or even the weather. Some people prefer writing by hand, while others enjoy typing it up. Both have benefits; writing by hand slows the process down (which is a good thing, in this situation), making the process more focussed, and it avoids any distractions that come from working on a computer. Typing on a computer is faster, meaning you can keep up with your thoughts, allows for searching through your entries at a later time, and offers things like embedding links, images, etc. It's entirely up to you how to approach a journaling practice, if you wish to begin one. It's just a matter of experimenting with different approaches and tools.

One particularly useful way of thinking about journaling is as “thinking by writing”, or “writing as thinking”. In this approach, journaling is thinking out loud, while logging it all. It's almost like having a conversation with yourself on paper/screen.

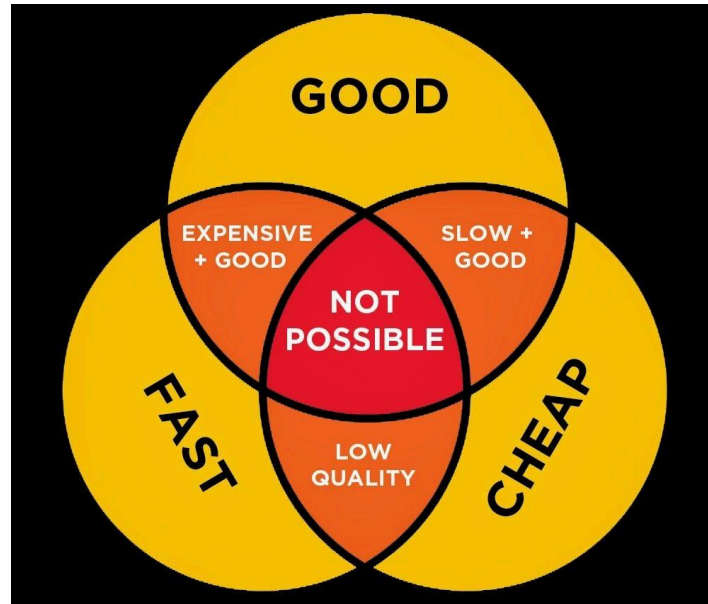
There are a range of different valid approaches to journaling, such as gratitude journaling, freewriting and prompted reflections. Gratitude journaling involves writing regularly about things you're grateful for – either by talking about them at length, or just listing a few things each day. Freewriting consists of writing for a period of time without prompts or guide, without stopping. Prompted reflections involves responding to a set of questions to enable structured reflection (similar to how you've worked with project reflections in the past). Some prompts might lead you towards an emotional check-in: *How am I feeling about my current projects or professional growth? Are there any specific feelings—positive or negative—that stand out? Why do I think I feel this way?* Or, you might carry out a self-assessment: *What did I achieve in my last project, and what would I like to improve on in future projects? How could journaling help track this progress?*

Often, a journaling practice will involve bits of each of these approaches, by perhaps beginning with a short list of things you're grateful for, then freewriting for a period of time, before shortly answering various prompts about the previous day or the day ahead, or current work.

All you really need is a notebook and pen, or a writing software platform. For the latter, [Obsidian](#) (my personal favourite) or [Notion](#) are good options, but you could also just use [Google Docs](#) or Microsoft Word.

Week 5 - Skill Diversification and Income Streams

Quality, Speed and Cost of Services



The services people offer have three main ‘aspects’: firstly, the **speed** at which they are carried out, second, the **quality** of the outcomes, and third, the **price** charged to the client/customer.

Each of these elements have impacts and dependencies on the others. You might notice in the image above that the orange outcomes are the opposite of the adjacent yellow aspect. If something is produced quickly and doesn’t cost much, it will typically be of lower quality and value, and perhaps also easily replicable. If something is carried out quickly but the output is of high quality, the cost to the client is expected to be high.

According to this diagram, it is impossible for a service to be cheap, carried out quickly, and of good quality. Of course, there are exceptions to this, but it’s useful to consider this “holy grail” of trade that both suppliers and customers of the services seek. It may help explain the direction of quite a bit of our modern technology: we want high quality things arriving to us quickly without us having to pay heaps for it. For service providers, manufacturers and organisations, this venn diagram is a major arena of competition.

Freelancing & Employment Markets

Freelancing is a form of self-employment where individuals offer their services to clients on a project- or contract basis, rather than working as a full-time employee for a single employer. Freelancers typically have the flexibility to choose their clients, set their own schedules, and determine their rates. They are often hired for specific skills or expertise and may work for multiple clients simultaneously.

Employment markets (aka “Labour markets”) refer to the supply and demand dynamics of jobs and labour within a particular economy or industry. Just like any market, there is something being ‘sold’ – or transactions being made – at a price based on the concepts of supply and demand; the price is determined by the meeting point of a) what a

seller is willing to sell something at, and b) what a buyer is willing to buy it at (see below for more information on supply and demand). The thing being sold in employment markets is *human labour* – through the process typically called **employment or hiring**. In short, employment markets represent the interaction between employers seeking workers with specific skills and individuals offering their services or labour. They can vary by location, sector, and skill level, and are influenced by factors such as economic conditions, technological changes, and shifts in consumer demand.

Supply and Demand

The role of supply and demand is crucial in determining rates for services in any market, including freelancing and creative industries.

- When demand for a particular service is high but the supply of skilled professionals offering that service is low, the rates tend to rise. Clients are willing to pay more to secure the limited availability of professionals with the desired skills.
- On the other hand, when there is an oversupply of professionals offering the same service, and demand is low, rates generally decrease, as clients have more options to choose from and may opt for the lowest-cost providers.

Where things get a little complicated is when you begin to consider why things might be in demand, or why there is an oversupply of professionals offering the same service. This is why it can be beneficial to develop a strong skill set in one particular, narrow area – a process called ‘specialisation’. Specialising in one particular area means that you reduce the risk of working in a saturated employment market by offering something that not many other people can. This counters issues relating to supply, but what about demand? Demand is a dependant on a range of external factors such as trends and movements, and new technologies; either creating demand for a particular skill if the technology results in a new field consider the rise of the need for video editing and short music pieces that grew from the arrival of social media, or reducing it if the technology makes the skill redundant – consider the reduction in the need for copywriters caused by the arrival of ChatGPT.

It’s useful to consider these two questions relating to the supply and demand of your skills:

1. What skills do you think are highly in demand in your industry?
2. How have supply and demand for these skills changed in recent years?

Staying Up To Date

In the creative industries, it is crucial to stay up to date with the relevant knowledge of your field. This includes everything from industry changes, technologies, techniques, trends and aesthetic styles, etc. There are plenty of ways to stay up to date, including (but not limited to):

- Attending industry conferences, webinars, or workshops
- Following industry leaders on social media or subscribing to their newsletters
- Joining professional associations or online communities
- Regularly reading industry publications, blogs, or podcasts
- Engaging in continuous professional development (certifications, courses, etc.)

References

Allen, D. (2015). *Getting Things Done: The Art of Stress-Free Productivity*. Penguin. (Original work published 2001)